ALMAU – TOLYQ ADAM 2026

INTERNATIONAL CONFERENCE 2026

The University of the Future as an Environment for the Development of a Whole Person

The Heritage of the Great Steppe and Contemporary Solutions

30–31 October 2026 | Almaty Management University (AlmaU) | Almaty, Kazakhstan

CONFERENCE CONCEPT and PROGRAMME

1. CONFERENCE CONCEPT

KEY QUESTION
What kind of person should the university of the future seek to develop?

The rapid advancement of artificial intelligence, the transformation of professions, and growing uncertainty are fundamentally changing the way we prepare people for the future. Universities must not only respond to the current needs of society and the labour market but also anticipate change—preparing students for a world whose contours are still taking shape.

This brings into focus not only professional preparation but also the development of qualities that remain valuable regardless of technological and professional change: independent thinking, the ability to learn and relearn, adaptability, agency, responsibility, ethical judgement, and the capacity to make decisions under conditions of uncertainty.

The conference approaches the university not merely as an institution for the transmission of knowledge, but as a holistic cultural and educational environment in which the person of the future is formed. Its concept brings together three perspectives: the intellectual and cultural heritage of the Great Steppe; TOLYQ ADAM as AlmaU's contemporary educational model; and international university practices of whole-person education.

IDEA

INTELLECTUAL LOGIC

The Great Steppe → human qualities shaped by the environment → TOLYQ ADAM as a contemporary educational model → international practices of the university of the future

GOAL

To develop a shared conceptual and practical understanding of how universities can intentionally design educational and cultural environments that foster the development of a whole person, drawing on the heritage of the Great Steppe and leading international practices in higher education; and to introduce TOLYQ ADAM to the international academic community.

TARGET AUDIENCE

University leaders and architects of educational models; faculty and researchers; representatives of government bodies and expert communities; employers and business leaders; international experts and partners.

THREE THEMATIC TRACKS

01 THE GREAT STEPPE
Not a historical retrospective in itself, but a search for the principles that shape the individual: agency, adaptability, responsibility, social connectedness, cultural openness, and the ability to act in conditions of uncertainty.

02 TOLYQ ADAM
AlmaU's contemporary educational model, in which the idea of holistic personal development has been institutionally embedded. In 2026, TOLYQ ADAM won the **Times Higher Education Awards Asia** in the **Teaching and Learning Strategy of the Year** category.

03 THE UNIVERSITY OF THE FUTURE
Moving from principles to practice: how universities around the world design environments that foster critical thinking, values, agency, social responsibility, a research culture, and the capacity for purposeful action.

2. PROGRAMME

Day 1 - 30 October |

FROM THE HERITAGE OF THE GREAT STEPPE TO THE UNIVERSITY OF THE FUTURE

09:00–09:30 — **PARTICIPANT REGISTRATION, WELCOME COFFEE, NETWORKING**

09:30–10:00 — **OFFICIAL OPENING**
Opening Remarks

10:00–10:30 — **KEYNOTE ADDRESS I**

Prof. Joo-Yup Lee — Canada, University of Toronto

"Whole Person" in Turkic and Qazaq Nomadic Societies: Inspiration for the Person of the Future

A scholar of the history of Central Eurasia and the Turco-Mongol world. His research focuses on statehood, identity, and the political and social organization of post-Mongol Central Eurasia. He is the author of Qazaqlïq, or Ambitious Brigandage, and the Formation of the Qazaqs (Brill, 2016), which received the 2017 Central Eurasian Studies Society Book Award, and The Turkic Peoples in World History (Routledge, 2023).

PANEL I. THE GREAT STEPPE — FROM HERITAGE TO THE PERSON OF THE FUTURE

PANEL FOCUS

To demonstrate that holistic personal development has deep historical and cultural foundations. The legacy of the Great Steppe is explored as a resource for rethinking the qualities required of the person of the future — a leader, citizen, and professional capable of navigating a complex and rapidly changing world.

10:30–10:45 — **ONLINE**

Marie Favereau — Associate Professor at Paris-Nanterre University

"How Past & Future interconnect: Teaching and Learning with the Golden Horde"

A scholar of the history of Central Eurasia and the Turco-Mongol world. His research focuses on statehood, identity, and the political and social organization of post-Mongol Central Eurasia. He is the author of Qazaqlïq, or Ambitious Brigandage, and the Formation of the Qazaqs (Brill, 2016), which received the 2017 Central Eurasian Studies Society Book Award, and The Turkic Peoples in World History (Routledge, 2023).

10:45–11:00

Prof. Peter Finke — Switzerland, University of Zurich

"Sociality in the Steppes: Three Lessons for the Contemporary World"

Professor of Social and Cultural Anthropology at the University of Zurich, an economic anthropologist and scholar of Central and Inner Asia. For more than three decades, he has studied pastoral nomadism, social relations, transformations, identity, and institutional change in Kazakhstan, Mongolia, and Uzbekistan.

11:00–11:15

Prof. Zira Nauryzbai — Kazakhstan, Almaty Management University (AlmaU)

"Why Were Kazakh Khans and Warriors Musicians? The Role of Music in the Formation of the Individual in Kazakh Culture"

Cultural studies scholar, philosopher, and researcher of Kazakh mythology and traditional culture; PhD, Professor of Practice at AlmaU. Her research focuses on the worldview of the Great Steppe, cultural identity, ethics, historical memory, and cultural codes.

11:15–11:30 — **ONLINE**

Prof. Mark Ingham — United Kingdom, University of the Arts London (UAL), London College of Communication

"Joyful Educational Encounters: Becoming Nomadic Learners and Rhizomatic Universities"

Professor of Nomadology and Senior Teaching Scholar at UAL, and Co-Chair of the UAL Professoriate. His research explores nomadic and critical pedagogies, rhizomatic learning, student agency, creativity, and experimental approaches to higher education, drawing in part on the philosophy of Deleuze and Guattari.

11:30–11:45 — **ONLINE**

Prof. Catherine Poujol — France, INALCO

"The Historical and Cultural Heritage of Kazakh Nomadism and Its Influence on the Contemporary Citizen"

Professor of Central Asian History and Civilization at INALCO and a specialist in the modern and contemporary history of the region. His research focuses on political and social transformations, identities, religious change, and international relations. He is the author of more than one hundred academic publications.

11:45–12:00	**Assoc. Prof. Ainash Mustoyapova — Kazakhstan, Karaganda Buketov University** *"The Nomadic Heritage as a Solid Foundation for a Successful Future: Worldview, Principles of Life, and Values"* Researcher of nomadic civilization, cultural history, decolonization, historical memory, and Kazakh identity. Author of more than 70 academic and educational publications; his recent books include Nomads: In Search of the Lost Path (2025).
12:00–12:30	**Q&A** **Panel I Participants** *"What Can the Great Steppe Teach the Person of the Future?"*
12:30–13:00	**SPECIAL BOOK PRESENTATION** **Book Presentation: "Signs of Heaven and Earth: The Human Being in Sacred Space"** *A Special Cultural and Intellectual Event*
13:00–14:00	**LUNCH**
14:00–14:30	**KEYNOTE ADDRESS II — THE TOLYQ ADAM MODEL** **Сапаргалиева А.Ж. — Kazakhstan, Almaty Management University (AlmaU)** **School of Social Sciences and Transformative Humanities, Dean, PhD, Associate Professor** *"TOLYQ ADAM: From the Philosophy of the Whole Person to an Institutional Educational Model"* TOLYQ ADAM has been implemented at AlmaU since 2023 as an integrated set of interconnected courses and practices aimed at the holistic development of students. The model is conceptually grounded in Abai's philosophy of harmony between the mind, heart, and will. In 2026, TOLYQ ADAM won the **Times Higher Education Awards Asia** in the **Teaching and Learning Strategy of the Year** category.
14:30–15:00	**BOOK PRESENTATION — TOLYQ ADAM** **A University Model for Whole-Person Education** Presentation of a book exploring the philosophical foundations of the model and their application in contemporary educational practice at AlmaU.
15:00–15:15	**INTERNATIONAL KEYNOTE III | ONLINE** **Michelle Hoffman — USA, Bard College, Institute for Writing & Thinking (IWT)** *"Imagining Writing in the University of the Future"* Deputy Director of the Institute for Writing & Thinking и Co-Director of the Center for Liberal Arts and Sciences Pedagogy at Bard College. Работает на пересечении writing-based pedagogy, философии и истории образования и Liberal Arts; участвует в AI Working Group IWT.
15:15–15:30	**Abai Kazakh National Pedagogical University (KazNPU)**
15:30–15:45	**COFFEE BREAK**

PANEL II. THE UNIVERSITY OF THE FUTURE: GLOBAL PRACTICES OF WHOLE-PERSON DEVELOPMENT

PANEL FOCUS

From principles to practice: how universities across different countries design educational environments that develop not only professional competencies, but also critical thinking, values, agency, social responsibility, a research culture, and the capacity for purposeful action.

15:45–16:00	**Prof. Pamela Pui Wan Leung — Hong Kong, The Education University of Hong Kong (EdUHK)** *"Humanity Can Broaden the Way: Cultivating Values in University Students of the Future"* Acting Dean Faculty of Humanities, Executive Co-Director Academy for Educational Development and Innovation и Professor (Practice) в EdUHK. Her professional work encompasses teacher education, assessment for learning, multilingual and inclusive education, innovation, and the integration of generative AI into humanities education.
16:00–16:15	**Prof. Peter Finke — Switzerland, University of Zurich** *"University Alliances: A Model for the Future?"* Vice-Dean for Study Affairs Faculty of Arts and Social Sciences, University of Zurich; участник Una Europa. In the second panel, he participates not as a researcher of nomadic societies, but as a representative of institutional university practice.
16:15–16:30	**Dr. Asmita Dani — India, Symbiosis International (Deemed University)** *"From Curriculum Reform to Whole-Person Education: The Symbiosis Experience"* Dean and Professor of Academics, Head of Global Engagement and Partnerships (South Asia & ASEAN). Her expertise includes curriculum reform, multidisciplinary education, internationalisation, global citizenship, equity, and sustainability.
16:30–16:45	**Prof. Pascal Taranto — France, Aix-Marseille Université** *"From the Labs to Society: HSS Innovation as a Key Feature of Next-Generation Universities"* Professor of Philosophy at Aix-Marseille Université and Director of the Centre Gilles Gaston Granger. He leads the development of LABΩ, a collaborative research environment focused on collective intelligence, peer review, and new forms of knowledge production, including the use of AI agents
16:45–17:00	**Daniyar Karabayev — Kyrgyzstan, American University of Central Asia (AUCA)** *"Seventy Skills Are Not Enough: Liberal Arts Education and the Kyrgyz Ideal of the Whole Person"* Dean and Senior Lecturer, Faculty of Liberal Arts and Sciences, AUCA. His academic and administrative work focuses on Liberal Arts and interdisciplinary university education.
17:00–17:15	**Aigerim Tarbagatayeva — Kazakhstan, Nazarbayev University Research Centre for Entrepreneurship (NURCE)** *"Human-centered entrepreneurship for a sustainable future through Tolyk Adam philosophy"* Business trainer, life coach, motivation speaker and mentor; Head of the Association of Business Trainers; Researcher and PhD student at Nazarbayev University Research Centre for Entrepreneurship (NURCE).
17:15–17:30	**PANEL II — Q&A** **Участники Panel II**
17:30–18:00	**CLOSING DISCUSSION — DAY 1** **Moderators and Key Speakers** *Key Takeaways from Day 1*
18:00–20:00	**CONFERENCE DINNER** **International Guests and Participants**

DAY 2 — DISTINGUISHED LECTURES & WORKSHOPS
From Dialogue to Practice

DAY TWO: FORMAT AND APPROACH
The second day brings the conference themes into a more open academic and practice-oriented format. Distinguished scholars deliver extended lectures for the university community, followed by a series of workshops showcasing specific educational practices.

10:00–11:00

DISTINGUISHED LECTURE I

Prof. Joo-Yup Lee (TBC)
"Qazaqliq and the Formation of the Qazaqs"
An extended academic lecture for AlmaU students, faculty, and researchers.

11:00–12:00

DISTINGUISHED LECTURE II

Prof. Pascal Taranto
"A Case Study in Innovation: The LABΩ Collaborative Platform and Its AI Agents"
An in-depth exploration of a specific innovative research platform at Aix-Marseille Université.

12:00–13:00

DISTINGUISHED LECTURE III

Prof. Zira Nauryzbai
"Küy Is the Whisper of Tengri: Music in Kazakh Mythology and Culture"
An extended lecture on music, mythology, and the cultural code of the Great Steppe.

13:00–14:00 — **LUNCH**

WORKSHOPS — UNIVERSITY PRACTICES IN ACTION

14:00–15:00 | WORKSHOP 1 — TOLYQ ADAM / ALMAU
TOLYQ ADAM — Practical Lab: Tools, Courses, Methodologies, and Opportunities for Adapting the Model. A practical introduction to TOLYQ ADAM tools, courses, and methodologies, followed by a discussion of how they can be adapted to other university contexts.

15:00–16:00 | WORKSHOP 2 — EDUHK
"Values-based teaching, assessment, and AI for meaningful learning"

16:00–17:00 | WORKSHOP 3 — DR. ASMITA DANI / SYMBIOSIS
Whole-Person Education in Practice: Lessons from Symbiosis. Practical approaches to integrating whole-person education into curriculum design, teaching practices, and student development, drawing on the experience of Symbiosis International (Deemed University).

17:00–17:30

OFFICIAL CLOSING

Assylbek Kozhakhmetov — President and Founder of AlmaU
Conference Outcomes and Future Directions for International Cooperation

17:30–18:30

CLOSING DINNER / RECEPTION

Speakers and participants